Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Emily Dickinson's "[The mushroom is the elf of plants]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the figures of comparison—similes, metaphors, and allusions—in Emily Dickinson's "[The mushroom is the elf of plants]" include

alliteration,
allusion,
antecedent,
assonance,
connotation,
consonance,
contrast,
denotation,
enjambment,
imagery,
metaphor,
paradox,
personification,
rhyme,
rhythm,
sigmatism,
simile,
speaker,
tenor and vehicle, and
tone.

The young writer should recognize that Dickinson's poem progresses through a series of comparisons, the overwhelming majority of which are metaphors and similes, the allusion ending the poem characterizing the capstone comparison. The writer might focus on the shift that occurs in line 13, at which point the speaker offers a personal assessment of the nature of the relationship that the mushroom has with the rest of the vegetation, including the tare (line 8), which is also considered unwanted.

The contestant might instead focus on the imagery that is embedded in the vehicles of the comparisons: an elf, not an elf, a snake, a tare, a juggler, a germ of an alibi, a bubble (a pair of similes balancing as a paradox), an offshoot of the summer's otherwise carefulness, and the pointed last clause, which declares that the mushroom is Judas.

The thread of comparison that culminates in the speaker's allusion to Judas Iscariot as son despised (lines 17-19)—the mushroom as an outcast from the world of vegetation—gives the writer an opportunity to address the personification of grass being pleased with the mushroom as intermittent interloper.

Any recognition of the poet's inclination to speak in terms of nature (obvious), religion (the allusion), or death (the mushroom's life cycle) should be *specific* to the poem's imagery and diction.